



SHAHBAD HOCKEY CENTRE, HARYANA

GUTS, GLORY, GIRLS

Even as the Indian women's hockey team missed the bus to Beijing in the Olympic qualifier in Russia in April, there was a silver lining in the moment of despair. It was that Shahbad had once again underscored its status as the font of women's hockey in India. Seven players, including the reigning captain Surinder Kaur of the 16-member squad, belonged to this nondescript Haryana town. Of India's 14 goal tally in five matches, 13 were scored by the Shahbad girls. More remarkably, its youngest member, Rani Devi, a fourteen-and-half-year-old, was adjudged the best player in the qualifier as well as two four-nation tournaments that India played in Europe. She's now the toast of Indian women's hockey.

Turning up such prodigal players has been a way of life at Shahbad. In the last decade-and-a-half, it has produced as many as 25 international hockey players—six of whom were part of the silver-medallist team at the 2006 Doha Asian Games. The driving force behind Shahbad's spectacular track record is Baldev Singh, an intrepid, tough-talking coach of the Haryana Sports Department, who has single-handedly honed the skills

of a generation of shy and precocious girls, mostly from poor families with no sporting tradition. "I train them to play like men," says Singh, who was recently given a two-year extension and a cash award of Rs 10 lakh from the Haryana Government in recognition of his role in putting Shahbad on the country's hockey map. His protegee couldn't agree more. "His training infuses tremendous fighting spirit," says Surinder Kaur, 26, daughter of a farm labourer, who is affectionately called a goal machine.

Powered by the Shahbad girls who virtually form the entire state team, Haryana has won the national school hockey championship in the under-14 and under-17 categories for the last four years. Shahbad has claimed the Jawaharlal Nehru Hockey Tournament for schools (under 17 years) 10 out of 14 times in the past. It has also lifted the hockey championship cup in the past three National Games. Among the current crop of 70 trainees under his wings, seven-year-old Amandeep Kaur is the youngest, her height barely matching the length of the stick she effortlessly holds. Plans are afoot to build a 60-bed hostel at Shahbad to expand the influx of talent from all over Haryana.

Excelling in hockey has meant a major windfall for Shahbad players, both in terms of cash rewards as well as jobs with the Indian Railways. Senior players like Kaur and Suman Bala, the veteran full back of the Indian team, are helping Singh's effort by turning mentors to the trainees. It's not surprising that hockey has become a prime passion amongst the girls of Shahbad, which is fast becoming to women's hockey what Sansarpur, in Punjab, was to the men's game.

by Ramesh Vinayak

PASSPORT TO WORK

For the Shahbad players, hockey has become a passport to jobs with the Indian Railways. In the last decade, 35 of them have got jobs with the Northern Railways and now form a bulk of its hockey team.

"I train these women to play like men."

BALDEV SINGH, DEPUTY DIRECTOR AND HOCKEY COACH, HARYANA SPORTS DEPARTMENT



IT'S A GOAL: Baldev Singh with the women's hockey team